
TRANSPORTATION DEMAND PROJECTS IN VERMONT

2019-2024



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Marketing TDM

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Introduction

Vermont is becoming more walkable, more bikeable, more rideable.

Major intersections in Rutland and Hartford are being revamped to make more space for bikes. South Burlington now has more than [22 miles of shared use paths](#)¹. Milton has upwards of 7 miles of interconnected sidewalk. Bike-share makes it easier for Burlington-area residents to pedal instead of drive. New paths allow young residents of Bennington housing developments to walk to schools. A rec path bridge connects cycling commuters from downtown Newport to North Country Hospital.

95 transportation demand projects implemented since 2019 are making it easier for Vermonters to get around without a car.

This research presents 95 different initiatives realized since 2019 that are making it easier for Vermonters to get around their communities without a car. This review focused on changes to infrastructure of all sizes and scopes, from installation of rectangular rapid flashing beacons that improve pedestrian crossing safety, to construction of separate multi-purpose paths. There are also projects that help Vermonters use alternatives to single-occupancy vehicles, like e-bike libraries, expanded transit centers, and micro-transit systems.

¹ "South Burlington makes progress getting people out of their cars," Andrew Chalnack, *The Other Paper*, Apr. 18, 2024: https://www.vtcng.com/otherpapersbvt/opinion/opinion_columns/south-burlington-makes-progress-getting-people-out-of-their-cars/article_522acf54-fdb2-11ee-bfd6-3b7e18d0bc4c.html

Five pedestrians and one cyclist were killed on Vermont roads in 2023². That fatalities continue to happen regularly on Vermont roadways is a strong motivator for making the transportation system safer for non-single-occupancy vehicle users.

Support for these projects is growing for other reasons, too. Mitigating the impacts of climate change by reducing greenhouse gas emissions is driving interest in alternatives to single-occupancy vehicles. Many residents are also concerned with transportation equity; for people who cannot drive, have a disability, or do not have access to a car, many Vermont communities are difficult to navigate. Walking, biking and public transit infrastructure can make a huge difference.

Our research found that media coverage of transportation demand management (TDM) projects varies. While projects that are in high-profile areas or involve substantial investment are often featured, the majority are not well-covered, and many smaller initiatives don't appear in news media at all.

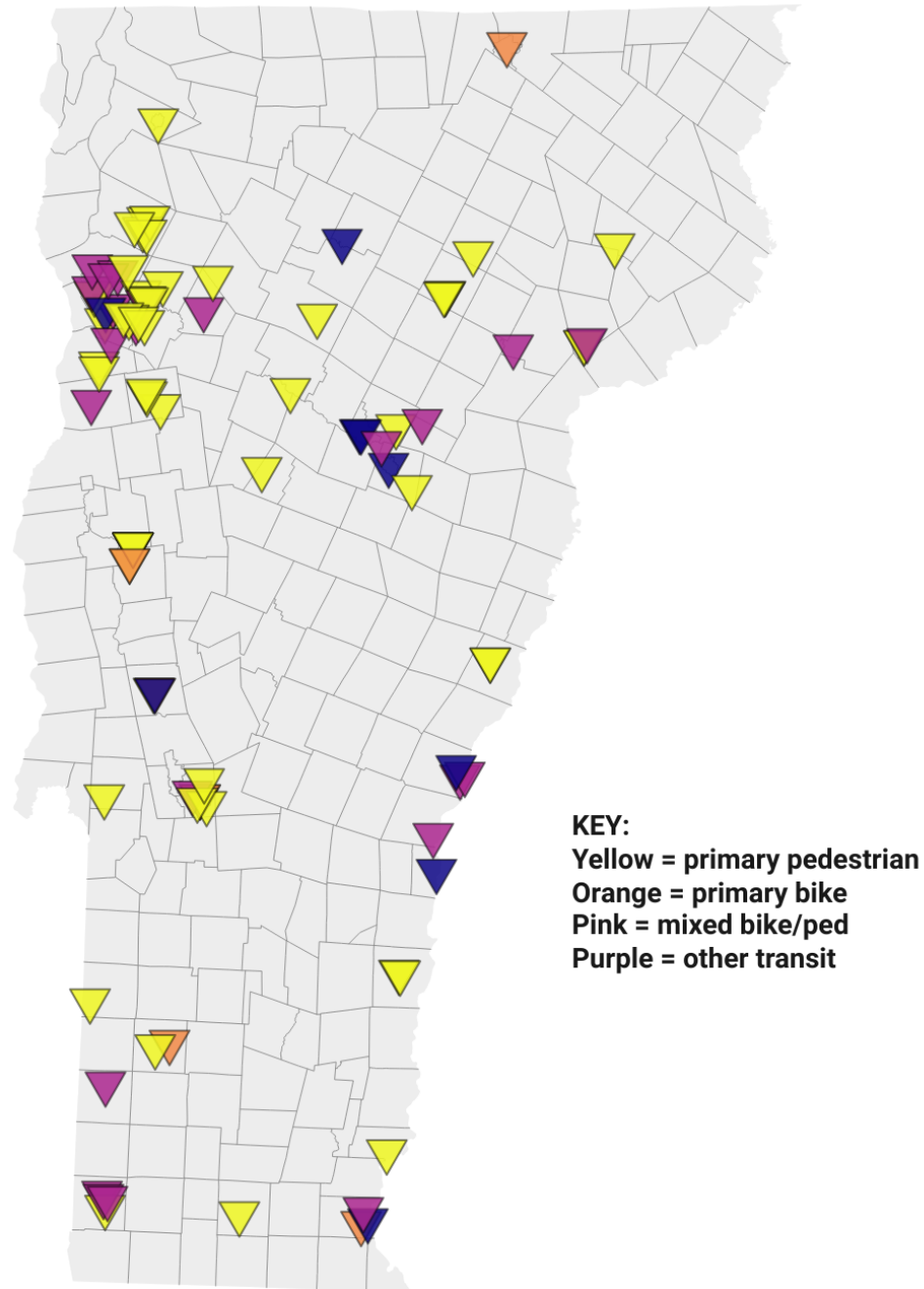
This report and accompanying map³ present a broad array of TDM projects that have been completed around the state. We analyze media coverage of non-car infrastructure, and, based on our analysis and interviews with stakeholders, make recommendations that can enhance public communications going forward.

² Vermont Agency of Transportation Fatal Crash Dashboard:
<https://app.powerbigov.us/view?r=eyJrljojZU1OTkyMzUtMTRiZC00NWExLWJmMTQqtZDk0ZWFiZjllZDJjIiwidCI6IjIwYyQ5MzNiLWJhYWQtdNDMzYyO5YzAyLTcwZWRIYzc1NTIjNiJ9&pageName=ReportSectioncfd3f843935219394065>

³ Access data map online at this address: <https://www.datawrapper.de/> /ZTcKt/

TDM projects implemented 2019-2024

Transportation Demand Management initiatives implemented in Vermont, including pedestrian and bike infrastructure and alternatives to single-occupancy vehicles.



Report: Transportation Demand Projects in Vermont 2019-2024, University of Vermont, August 2024

Map: Visualization by Amelia Veleber and Elizabeth Hewitt • Source: UVM TDM research 2019-2024 • Created with Datawrapper

Access data visualization online: https://www.datawrapper.de/_/ZTCkT/

Data Collection Process

This list includes a wide swath of transportation demand management projects implemented around Vermont since 2019, from road redesigns that result from years of state and local planning, to small-scale changes spearheaded by community members that make neighborhoods more walkable. There is currently no centralized system tracking TDM projects around Vermont. In order to capture projects of all scopes, we drew from a variety of state and local government sources, media reports, and community outreach. Collecting and sharing information about these projects gives communities more opportunities to learn from each other.

The Complete Streets Reporting Tool⁴, managed by the Vermont Agency of Transportation, tracks transportation infrastructure construction projects and how they incorporate the principles of Complete Streets, which include features for bikes and pedestrians. Projects listed in this platform have been contracted, though the list does not note when construction has been completed. While some local authorities contribute to the tracking tool, it does not include all projects in the state.

We reached out to all 11 of Vermont's regional planning commissions, receiving data from seven. We also circulated requests for input to municipal officials, advocacy organizations, and local bike-walk groups around the state.

This list also includes projects that were awarded funding through federal and state grant programs, including the Bike and Pedestrian Program and the Transportation Alternatives Program, both managed by the Vermont Agency of Transportation, and Agency of Commerce and Community Development programs including the

⁴ See the Vermont Agency of Transportation website: <https://vtrans.vermont.gov/highway/complete-streets>

Downtown Transportation Fund and the Better Connections program. We reviewed projects supported by an array of organizations and community groups, including AARP, Chittenden Area Transportation Management Association, Local Motion, the Vermont Natural Resources Council, and Vital Communities.

The list also reflects thorough review of coverage of transportation projects in local and statewide news media and posts on social media. We tracked and confirmed projects through other documentary sources, including engineering firm project summaries and developments noted in municipal government documents, such as annual town reports and select board meeting minutes.

Because projects are not tracked centrally, and many are small in scope, this likely does not capture every TDM project completed in the state over the last five years. However, it does provide a representative sample of initiatives that have been realized across Vermont communities.

Media Coverage of TDM Projects

As the list of projects compiled through this research shows, there is tremendous diversity in the scope and types of projects completed around Vermont. Some were undertaken as part of routine roadworks led by VTrans, like the resurfacing of Route 30 between Brattleboro and Newfane that incorporates bike lanes and pedestrian upgrades. Some are the result of innovative local municipal processes for installing non-car infrastructure options, like the Penny for Paths initiative in South Burlington. Many projects emerge out of grassroots, volunteer-led efforts to improve walking, biking and non-car transit options in their own communities.

Just as these projects vary, so does the public attention they receive. Bike and pedestrian infrastructure projects tend to have more news media coverage at early stages in the realization of projects. New proposals to build or modify infrastructure are often reported in media stories. Milestone procedural steps, like select board votes or announcements



Figure 1: Bike lane on Park St in Brandon

of grant awards that move a project toward realization, also tend to generate news coverage. Media reports sometimes cover opposition to a project, or discussion in public meetings. Another benchmark that tends to generate media coverage is the start of construction, especially if it involves disruption to traffic.

Less common is media coverage marking the completion of non-car infrastructure projects. Major construction projects, with a bike or pedestrian component, are often covered. News organizations reported the conclusion of a major overhaul of US Route 7 through downtown Brandon⁵, for instance, which included substantial upgrades to sidewalks and pedestrian infrastructure. Official statements from the state, municipalities or other groups announcing the completion of projects also attract attention. A news report⁶ in 2019 picked up on a VTrans press release marking the completion of a new bridge on Route 14 in East Montpelier⁷, which included a 900-foot extension of sidewalk and pedestrian crossing improvements. Multiple news outlets published about the opening of a section of multi-use path in

⁵ “No More Cones And Construction: Brandon Open For Business,” Vermont Public, Nov. 13, 2019:

<https://www.vermontpublic.org/vpr-news/2019-11-13/no-more-cones-and-construction-brandon-open-for-business>

⁶ “East Montpelier bridge project complete,” WCAX, July 1, 2019: <https://www.wcax.com/content/news/East-Montpelier-bridge-project-complete-512071211.html>

⁷ “Agency of Transportation completes VT 14 East Montpelier bridge,” VTrans, July 1, 2019:

<https://vtrans.vermont.gov/sites/aot/files/press-releases/07.01.2019%20-%20AOT%20Announces%20Completion%20of%20VT-14%20Bridge.pdf>

Bennington in 2022⁸ after town officials made a statement. Events also attract attention, like the installation of a bridge on Rutland City’s Creek Path in August 2024⁹, or the official opening of a new bridge on the Cross Vermont Trail over the Winooski River in East Montpelier in 2022¹⁰.

Public Communications Challenges

In interviews, planners, advocacy organization leaders, municipal officials and community advocates shared that publicity of TDM projects is important for several reasons. Public communications can raise awareness within communities so residents are more likely to use infrastructure and alternatives to single-occupancy vehicles. It can help generate new projects: advocates relayed that when residents of one community are trying to implement non-car infrastructure, they often look for examples in other communities to get a sense of the possibilities and the process involved. Publicity of projects, and their impact, also brings attention from state and regional funding organizations.

Stakeholders identified a few key challenges around TDM communications:

1. Timeline:

TDM projects take years, sometimes even more than a decade, to complete, from the initial proposal to the realization of the project. While many projects go through significant public review, the lengthy timeline means that even if there was support in early stages, by the time construction begins, enthusiasm may have waned.

⁸ “New Bennington rail trail opens,” Bennington Banner, Nov. 22, 2022: https://www.benningtonbanner.com/community-news/new-bennington-rail-trail-opens/article_e94cfc96-6aa5-11ed-b62d-3b232b275417.html.

⁹ “Rutland Creek Path bridge installed,” Rutland Herald, Aug. 1, 2024: https://www.rutlandherald.com/news/local/rutland-creek-path-bridge-installed/article_309947ee-502d-11ef-82ca-5f821a5d087f.html.

¹⁰ “A New Bridge Marks a Milestone for the Cross Vermont Trail,” Seven Days, June 1, 2022: <https://www.sevendaysvt.com/arts-culture/a-new-bridge-marks-a-milestone-for-the-cross-vermont-trail-35697297>

2. Lack of centralized reporting:

It can be difficult to know what projects have been fully implemented. The completion of construction is not always well-noted, particularly smaller projects or modifications that are made as components of bigger transportation infrastructure overhauls. Often these elements do not get much public attention. Further, the processes and opportunities through which state and local actors can work together toward TDM infrastructure changes, like through municipal bike-pedestrian master plans, are not always clearly understood. Better tracking could increase awareness of the process.

3. Public opinion:

TDM projects can be met with opposition. For instance, recent projects that reduce travel lanes for vehicles, like road diet projects in Rutland and Hartford, are often controversial. Even relatively minor changes, like proposals for pedestrian crossing lights¹¹ or signage and markings for bikes¹², can generate opposition. Advocates described a broader ongoing cultural discourse around transportation in individual communities and across the state.

While there are challenges in public communications, there are also strategies that make an impact. One common suggestion was highlighting the positive aspects of TDM projects, rather than taking an approach that focuses on negatives of current transportation system. Narratives that emphasize shame or guilt around driving, they say, tend not to be productive. Instead, a few suggestions:

¹¹ “Crosswalk controversy: Plan for warning lights at crosswalks has neighbors at odds,” NBC5, July 12, 2019: <https://www.mynbc5.com/article/crosswalk-controversy-plan-for-warning-lights-at-crosswalks-has-neighbors-at-odds/27966539>

¹² “A controversial road sign,” Sidenote, July 21, 2022: <https://www.sidenote.news/a-controversial-road-sign/>

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- **Transportation equity:** One in three U.S. residents do not drive¹³ — a category that includes kids, people with disabilities, people who can't afford or choose not to own a car, older adults and others. TDM projects can make Vermont communities more inclusive, one interviewee explained: “How we can make sure that everybody can get around to where they need to go?”
 - **Focus on the fun:** Using alternatives to single-occupancy vehicle, like biking, walking, and taking public transit, opens up new opportunities for exercise, interactions with neighbors, and ways to experience a place. As one advocate put it: “At the end of the day, it's fun.”
 - **Safety:** Sadly, cyclist and pedestrian fatalities and injuries continue to happen on Vermont roads. Emphasizing the safety aspect of projects is a strong public message. Installing protected bike lanes has been linked to reduction in total crashes of more than 30% for all users.¹⁴ Improved safety can be particularly important for non-drivers, who may be more vulnerable, such as children and older adults.

Communication Strategy

Recommendations

Our review of projects around Vermont presents many opportunities for highlighting TDM projects in ways that drive media coverage and public awareness of the significant progress that has been made in recent years around non-car transportation opportunities. While there is a story to be told about virtually all of these projects, some stand out:

¹³ Estimate from [AARP](#)

¹⁴ “The Traffic Calming Effect of Delineated Bicycle Lanes,” Journal of Urban Mobility, June 2024:

[https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2667091724000013#:~:text=Providing%20bicycle%20facilities%20\(e.g.%2C%20bike,roads%20\(FHWA%2C%202022](https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2667091724000013#:~:text=Providing%20bicycle%20facilities%20(e.g.%2C%20bike,roads%20(FHWA%2C%202022)

Milton: Sidewalk Gap Project

Since 2016, the Town of Milton has expanded its pedestrian system so there is now 7.25 miles of interconnected sidewalk. The town did this by building connections between pre-existing segments and creating new sidewalks at key points in the community, including through residential areas, and to Husky Technologies, a major employer.

It's a great example of how improving walkability can be incorporated in downtown revitalization. The town's process in realizing these efforts might also be useful as a case study because officials took different approaches to funding various segments, including state and federal grants, town funds, and private partnerships.

Drawing attention to Milton's pedestrian infrastructure can also benefit the town, as walkability can be a draw for potential residents as well as tourists.

South Burlington: Penny for Paths

South Burlington adopted an innovative approach to raising funds for bike and pedestrian projects: residents voted in 2018 to implement a one-cent increase on the tax rate. The city's Bicycle and Pedestrian Committee recommends projects to prioritize, often aimed at closing gaps between existing sidewalk and paths.

So far, the fund has supported projects including extension of a shared-use path at Allen Road and Spear Street, new crosswalks on Williston Road, and flashing beacons at crossings on Patchen Road. The city is working on closing a 3,500-foot gap in the Spear Street multi-use path, which will open an important connection between South Burlington and downtown Burlington. Coming up with funding for TDM projects is a common hurdle, so highlighting models like that in South Burlington could be informative for other municipalities.

Work=Play: Commuting by rec trail

Networks of separated multi-use trails are expanding across Vermont. Trail systems like the Lamoille Valley Rail Trail and Cross Vermont Trail often appear in media as recreational attractions. However, these trail networks are also attractive corridors for bike commuting away from vehicle traffic¹⁵, particularly as communities build out points of connection with trails, as in Hardwick and Johnson.

There are many opportunities around the state to highlight segments of trails that offer dual functional and recreational use. To point to a couple:

- **Newport:** The trail expansion between Prouty Beach and Bluffside Farm, including a new bridge over Scott's Cove, not only connected downtown with opportunities for recreation, it also opened a key connection for bike commuters to North Country Hospital. This and other efforts earned the health center a [Silver Bicycle Friendly Business Award](#) from the League of American Bicyclists.
- **East Montpelier:** The Cross Vermont Trail is completing a [connector trail to U-32 Middle & High School](#) in 2024, building on the installation of a key bridge over the Winooski River in 2021.

Transportation In Action

Events and activities that show TDM initiatives in use are a key opportunity for publicity.

While dedicated press events can be one approach, many transportation advocacy organizations around the state already regularly engage in activities that may be of

¹⁵ The [2022 Vermont State Highway Safety Office Attitude Survey](#) found that only 28% of respondents biked near active traffic during an average month. Of those, 79.5% were concerned over their personal safety without a designated bike lane, and 68% were concerned while in a designated bike lane.

interest to local news, with some outreach. As one news editor commented: stories come out of verbs, not nouns.

E-bike lending libraries, like the traveling fleet spearheaded by Vital Communities in the Upper Valley, show non-car transportation options in action. Organized group bike rides of new bikes lanes can draw attention and build confidence among community members to use the new infrastructure, noted one bike advocate. Even action earlier in the realization of TDM projects can provide easy opportunities for publicity: when community members go through one of AARP's Walk Audits, for instance, or pop-up demonstrations, like temporary traffic calming measures in Shelburne and Rutland.

Conclusion and Next Steps

Our research finds a broad array of initiatives that are making it easier in various ways for Vermonters to get around without a single-occupancy vehicle. In the state's population hubs and its rural villages, projects are changing streetscapes to be more walkable and bikeable. Innovative approaches are expanding non-car transit options. There is a lot that Vermonters can learn from each other.

Not noted in this list are the many projects in development that are scheduled to be realized in the next few years. It is our hope that this body of research, and analysis of public communications, can help to bring attention to these forthcoming projects as well.

There are many opportunities to build on and expand this research. For instance:

- **Develop a methodology to conduct annual surveys and regularly update the dataset with new projects.** This dataset was compiled through outreach, interviews and surveys. Many stakeholders were enthusiastic to contribute. Because there is no standard among the state and planning commission to track such projects, there are gaps in the data. A regular survey could help to fill gaps and to build on this research going forward.

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- **Improve the data visualization:** We have created a preliminary map visualizing TDM projects completed between 2019 and mid-2024. We recommend expanding on this to create a more advanced visualization, including photos of completed projects, that could both serve as a source of information for actors seeking to build out TDM projects, and as a resource for Vermont residents and visitors who are looking to enjoy the state without a car.
 - **Developing public communications resources:** Creating templates for press releases about the completion of projects or community events that highlight non-car infrastructure can help draw attention to these projects. These resources could reduce the public communication workload of small organizations and municipal/state government.
 - **Support independent transportation news reporting:** Partner with community papers or UVM's Community News Service to increase knowledge and reporting on community based TDM and related transportation projects around the state.

Acknowledgements:

This report was compiled with the help of Leah Golding, who assisted with research and drafting of this report. Amelia Veleber developed the map visualizing TDM projects around Vermont.

Appendix II

Sources

This data and report were informed conversations and email exchanges with dozens of stakeholders, who shared a range of perspectives and insights.

Researchers conducted interviews with:

- Christina Erickson, Local Motion, executive director
- Kati Gallagher, Vermont Natural Resources Council, Sustainable Communities Program director
- John Haffner, Vital Communities, executive director
- Jason Rasmussen and Logan Nicoll, Mount Ascutney Regional Commission executive director and planner
- Kelly Stoddard Poor, AARP VT, state director of outreach
- Don Turner, Town of Milton, town manager
- Bevin Barber-Campbell, bicycle advocate
- Maryann Zavez, Walk-Bike Randolph
- This research was also informed by informal conversations at the 2024 Bike/Walk Summit, with news editors, and email exchanges with many other regional and local stakeholders.